

BEYOND FAMILY

Some large Indian companies that have appointed non-family CEOs



WIPRO

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HERO MOTOCORP

Harshavardhan
Chitale



MARICO

Saugata Gupta



HCL TECHNOLOGIES

C. Vijayakumar



ADANI REALTY

Jackbastian
K. Nazareth



SONA COMSTAR

Vivek Vikram Singh



TATA GROUP

N. Chandrasekaran



MAHINDRA GROUP

Anish Shah



ASIAN PAINTS

Amit Syngle



VADILAL

Himanshu Kanwar

must also respect boundaries by transitioning into roles such as Chair, mentor, or Non-Executive Director.

Burman captures it best when he says succession is not about inheritance but about stewardship. “Treat the business and the family as two distinct institutions, each with its own space, respect, and governance.”

BALANCING LEGACY AND LEADERSHIP

Burman emphasises that succession at Dabur is not seen as a single moment but as a journey. Preparing a professional leader to take over requires a rigorous, multi-layered process rooted in foresight, capability mapping, and cultural alignment.

“Once the promoter family has decided to let a professional team manage day-to-day operations, it must step aside and allow them to run the show,” Burman maintains. The family, however, remains available to provide broad guidance or support if required.

The challenges of transitioning leadership without a clear family successor are often rooted in trust.

“Long-serving employees, customers, and partners have built deep trust with the family name and replacing that with a non-family professional requires deliberate credibility-building,” says Lakhotia.

Beyond that, risks of power vacuums or turf wars, within the family, among senior executives, or even in the promoter’s own mind, can emerge if boundaries are not clearly defined.

To prevent professional CEOs from being second-guessed or undermined, structured frameworks are essential: family values must be codified in a charter, shareholder alignment ensured, and legitimacy reinforced.

Succession, Lakhotia, echoing Burman, emphasises, should be seen as a journey rather than a one-time event. “Powers can be transferred gradually, early decisions hand-held, and outcomes evaluated before scaling responsibilities.”

Grooming and onboarding a non-family CEO is a process that requires constant handholding, structured exposure, and a gradual transfer of powers.

Lakhotia suggests exposing the CEO to founder values, family ethos, and organisational DNA through structured sessions, mentoring, and storytelling. In a landscape where tradition once dictated continuity, India’s family businesses are now crafting a new narrative—one that honours legacy while embracing change. **BT**